

C O M P 3 2 2

# Project kickoff: Phase 1

*Allocations, the next 15 days, and how to build a persona that actually means something*

---

**Hisham Ihshaish**

Birzeit University

Second semester 2025/26 | Wednesday 6 May 2026, morning session

# What we will cover today

*Six sections*

- 1 Allocations and revised timeline**
- 2 Reading your allocation row**
- 3 What is expected: individual assignment and Phase 1**
- 4 How to plan the next 15 days as a team**
- 5 Why personas matter, and what one looks like**
- 6 Common pitfalls and Q&A**

# The shape of the next 8 weeks

*Three phases that mirror the user-centred design cycle*

## Phase 1: Research

*Due Wed 20 May*

- Heuristic evaluation
- Interviews (2-4)
- Personas
- Scenarios
- Measurable requirements

## Phase 2: Design

*Due Wed 10 June*

- Design rationale
- Wireframes
- Interactive prototype
- Accessibility decisions

## Phase 3: Evaluation

*Due Wed 24 June*

- Usability testing
- SUS scores
- Heuristic re-evaluation
- Revision plan + reflection

*Phase 1 is 30% of the project mark. The project is 30% of the course grade. Phase 1 alone is roughly 9% of your total course grade.*

# Revised timeline

*Note the dates that have moved*

| Milestone                                       | Date                              | Status                              |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Allocations announced                           | <b>Wed 6 May 2026</b>             | <i>today (announced last night)</i> |
| G10/G16 merger reply (only if it does not work) | <b>Fri 8 May</b>                  |                                     |
| Individual assignment due                       | <b>Mon 11 May</b>                 | <i>unchanged</i>                    |
| Phase 1 due                                     | <b>Wed 20 May</b>                 | <i>shifted from 13 May</i>          |
| In-class quiz                                   | <b>Last week of May</b>           | <i>unchanged</i>                    |
| Phase 2 due                                     | <b>Wed 10 June</b>                | <i>shifted from 3 June</i>          |
| Phase 3 written deliverable due                 | <b>Wed 24 June</b>                | <i>shifted from 17 June</i>         |
| Final presentations                             | <b>Final teaching week (June)</b> | <i>slot confirmed in class</i>      |

*Green rows = changed from the original plan. No deadlines on Fridays.*

# Where to find everything

*Three documents on Ritaj plus the project specification*

## Allocations workbook

*Groups\_and\_Projects\_COMP322.xlsx*

Your team's row, distinct instances, revised timeline, and what to do this week.

## Phase 1 templates

*COMP322\_Phase1\_Templates.docx*

Heuristics quick-reference, evaluation log, severity scale, persona template with worked example.

## Project specification

*Project\_and\_Assignments\_Specification\_COMP322.pdf*

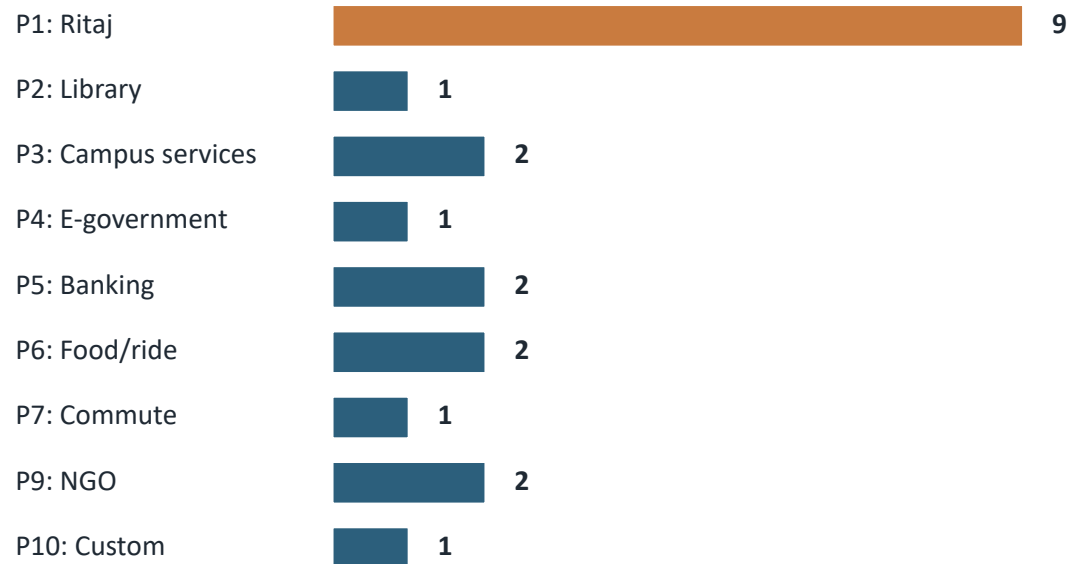
Full rubrics, Appendix B (interview guide), Appendix C (consent form), Appendix D (SUS).

*All three are linked in the Ritaj announcement.*

# How allocations were made

*Two principles, one chart*

## Demand for each project



## Two principles

### First preferences where possible.

Most teams got their first or second pick.

### Where multiple teams wanted the same project, allocate to distinct concrete instances so no two teams overlap.

Three Ritaj teams got registration, grades, and timetable. Two banking teams got Bank of Palestine and Arab Bank Palestine. Two food/ride teams got Talabat and Careem.

# How shared categories were split

*Same category, different concrete app; every team's work stays distinct*

|                                 |                                               |                                           |                                   |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| <b>Project 1: Ritaj</b>         | <b>G1</b> Course registration (to be changed) | <b>G8</b> Grades and academic record      | <b>G11</b> Schedule and timetable |
| <b>Project 5: Banking</b>       | <b>G3</b> Arab Bank Palestine (Arabi Mobile)  | <b>G13</b> Bank of Palestine (BOP mobile) |                                   |
| <b>Project 6: Food and ride</b> | <b>G4</b> Talabat (food delivery)             | <b>G12</b> Careem (ride-hailing)          |                                   |
| <b>Project 3: Campus</b>        | <b>G9</b> Event announcements                 | <b>G14</b> Room booking                   |                                   |
| <b>Project 9: NGO</b>           | <b>G10</b> NGO partner #1 (TBC)               | <b>G15</b> NGO partner #2 (TBC)           |                                   |

# Reading your allocation row

*Five fields you must understand before you start*

## **Allocated system / app**

The specific product. If named, you use exactly that one. If 'self-locate' (e.g. NGO), you find it.

## **Source: provided URL or self-locate?**

Where to find your system. If self-locate, your first task is to find and confirm it in your report.

## **Evaluation breadth**

Walk the whole system widely for the heuristic evaluation. Click around. Don't restrict yourselves to three screens.

## **Redesign scope**

The three specific user journeys you redesign. Only these. Do not try to redesign the whole system.

## **Distinct from**

Which screens or sub-areas are off-limits because another team owns them.



# Evaluation breadth vs redesign scope

*Two different activities, two different scopes*

## Heuristic evaluation: WIDE

**Walk the whole system. Click around. Sign up. Try to break it.**

Aim for 10-20 unique violations across whatever screens you reach.

If you only walk three screens, you'll only find three screens worth of problems. The whole point is to see how the system behaves under real exploration.

## Redesign: NARROW

**Redesign only the three user journeys in your row.**

Phase 2 wireframes and the prototype cover those three flows. Nothing else.

You have 8 weeks, not 8 months. A focused redesign of 3 journeys done well will score higher than a sprawling attempt at the whole system.

# If your service is not a named app: self-locate

*Affects: G6 (commute), G7 (e-gov), G9 (events), G10/G15 (NGO), G14 (room booking)*

## Named-product allocations

Talabat, Careem, Bank of Palestine, Arab Bank Palestine, Bab idDeir.

App / URL is named. Confirm version (for apps) and record it. Sign up if needed.

## Self-locate allocations

Civil-affairs e-services, NGO partners, room booking, event announcements, commuter carpool.

Your first job: search, find the official portal or app, confirm the URL, take screenshots of the entry points. Record this in the team-and-topic section of your Phase 1 report.

### Special case: nothing exists

If, like the commuter team (G6) or possibly an NGO team, you find no formal digital service exists (only informal WhatsApp groups, paper processes, or a Facebook page), that is itself a finding. Document it. Your project becomes a green-field design grounded in interview data, evaluated against the closest existing tool you can find.

# One admin note: Group 10 + Group 16

*Pending reply by Saturday 9 May*

## **Original Groups 10 and 16 each had only 2 members.**

Minimum team size is 3. Both teams have been merged into a single Group 10 of four members:

- **Ahmad Butmeh**
- **Shahd Ghanem**
- **Julia Duaibes**
- **Mohammad Tawafshah**

*Allocated project: NGO digital service (partner TBC, distinct from G15).*

**If this configuration cannot work for any of the four members, message me by Fri 8 May.**

Otherwise, this is your team for the term.

# Individual assignment: heuristic evaluation

Due Monday 11 May | 15% of course grade | 2-3 page report

## What you submit

A 2-3 page structured report containing:

- A public website or mobile app you have chosen, **NOT your team project**.
- At least 8 usability violations identified.
- For each violation: which heuristic, screenshot, description, severity (0-4), specific design fix.
- One paragraph naming the most severe problem and explaining why it matters.

## How it is marked (100 pts)

|                                  |    |
|----------------------------------|----|
| Heuristics correctly applied     | 25 |
| Severity ratings justified       | 20 |
| Design fixes specific & feasible | 25 |
| Screenshots clearly annotated    | 15 |
| Writing clear, structured        | 15 |

*This assignment is also your individual practice for the team's Phase 1 heuristic evaluation. The patterns you find solo on someone else's app are the patterns your team will look for next.*

# Phase 1: what your team submits

Due Wednesday 20 May | 30% of project mark | 5-7 pages plus appendix

| # | Component               | Length                      | What it must contain                                                                                                         | Pts |
|---|-------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| 1 | Team and topic          | <i>½ page</i>               | Members, working arrangements, scope statement, why the problem matters.                                                     | —   |
| 2 | Heuristic evaluation    | <i>1-2 pages</i>            | Min. 10 violations team-wide. Each: heuristic, screenshot, description, severity 0-4. Plus a paragraph on dominant patterns. | 25  |
| 3 | Exploratory interviews  | <i>1-2 pages + appendix</i> | Min. 2 interviews (3-4 better). 20-45 min each. Signed consent form (Appendix C). Notes per interview, key findings.         | 20  |
| 4 | Personas                | <i>1-2 pages</i>            | Two personas grounded in interview data. Standard fields. Evidence trail citing P1, P2, etc.                                 | 20  |
| 5 | Scenarios               | <i>½ - 1 page</i>           | Three short narratives showing how personas would realistically use the redesigned system.                                   | 15  |
| 6 | Measurable requirements | <i>½ page</i>               | 5-7 measurable usability targets, mapped to ISO 9241-11 goals (effective, efficient, satisfying, etc.).                      | 15  |

+ 5 points for clear writing and structure within the page limit. Total: 100.

# Why personas exist

*'Design for our students' is not a design target*



*If you design for everyone, you design for nobody.*

## First-year

Doesn't know what a prerequisite is. Cousin walks her through registration on WhatsApp.

## Commuter

Registers on her phone in 5-minute corridor windows. Slow Wi-Fi, mobile-only.

## Final-year

Power user. Wants a shortcut. Annoyed by repetitive flows.

# What a persona is, and what it isn't

*The discipline that distinguishes a real persona from a wishful one*

## A persona IS

- A portrait of a real user pattern, with a name, goals, frustrations, context.
- Built from interview evidence, not invention.
- One of two; never just one.
- A communication tool. "Would Lina do this?" is a sharper question than "would a student do this?"

## A persona is NOT

- A statistical average ("the average user is 21.4 years old").
- A stereotype ("the typical Palestinian student").
- An invented character ("let's say she's called Sara and she's 20").
- A permanent object; personas evolve as you learn more.

# Example: Lina Khoury

A persona built from four interviews. Every field cites evidence.

## From the interviews

|    |                                                                   |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| P1 | 2nd-year, commutes from Ramallah. Registers on phone.             |
| P2 | 1st-year. Cousin walked her through Ritaj on WhatsApp.            |
| P3 | 3rd-year. Says timetable "unreadable" on small screen.            |
| P4 | 4th-year. Power user. Wants the system to remember her electives. |

P1 + P2 + P3 share a pattern: mobile, time-pressured, registration unclear. → Lina.  
P4 is a different pattern. → second persona ("Layla") not shown here.

LK

Lina Khoury

Second-year CS student who registers on her phone between classes

Demographics

19, 2nd-year BSc CS, off-campus, 45-min commute (P1)

Goals

Register without conflicts; finish in <10 min; get advisor confirmation (P1, P2, P4)

Context of use

Mid-morning, between classes, on phone; sometimes asks cousin via WhatsApp (P1, P2)

Tech literacy

Android, Arabic UI preferred, comfortable but not power user (P1, P2)

Frustrations

Times out on slow Wi-Fi; timetable hard to read on mobile; vague "course full" messages (P2, P3 / P1, P3 / P2)

Quote

"I just want to know quickly if a course is full or not." — P1 (anonymised)

Evidence trail: P1, P2, P3 (3 of 4 interviews). Updated after each new interview.



# Common Phase 1 mistakes

*These are what cost marks in submissions. Pre-empt them.*

## Personas without evidence trails

*Cite participant codes (P1, P2) for every field. Empty is honest; invented is dangerous.*

## All severities are 3

*Use the three sub-factors: frequency, impact, persistence. A 3 needs at least two factors high.*

## Heuristic violations that aren't violations

*'The colours are ugly' is not Heuristic 4 (consistency). Pick the most specific heuristic that fits.*

## Scenarios that read like feature lists

*Scenarios are stories. 'At 10:45am, Lina opens Ritaj on her phone, wanting to add an elective...' Not bullets.*

## Convenience-sample interviews

*Real users, not roommates. Outside the team. Mix of contexts (year, department, device).*

## Unmeasurable usability requirements

*Numbers, time, error rates. 'Easy to use' is not a requirement. 'Complete in under 4 min with  $\leq 1$  error' is.*

***Questions? Bring them now, or to office hours this week. Phase 1 starts today.***